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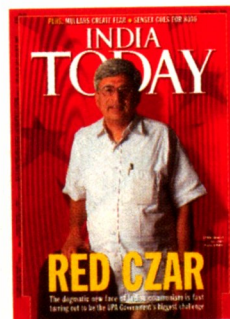
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Indian politics has reached a strange impasse. None of the political parties wants an election but ironically that's what they all seem to be working towards. The Congress is seemingly standing firm on its Indo-US nuclear deal while the Left is warning them of "serious consequences for the Government and the country". Much to the annoyance of the Left, they are on the same side of the fence as their bete noire BJP which is busy playing the Opposition, forgetting they are the ones whose pioneering work in moving closer to America made the nuclear deal possible. UNPA is opposing it in the hope of catering to the Muslim vote bank as America is perceived as anti-Muslim. It is an unholy political mess which raises many questions.

Why did Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, with uncharacteristic aggression, bait the Left in an interview given to a Kolkata newspaper when he said on the nuclear deal, "I told them to do whatever they want to do, if they want to withdraw support, so be it...." He has succumbed to the Left on many major economic issues so why did he choose to stake his reputation and Government on the nuclear issue which has no election appeal? The negotiations for the deal started in July 2005. Why didn't the Left warn of serious consequences then? After the prime minister's Parliament speech, they raised



Our Sept 2005 cover

nine objections to the deal and implied if these were overcome it was not a problem. The prime minister claims they have not crossed the redlines, so why the threats now? Has the Left shifted the goalposts? Even if the Government survives by making compromises, what will be the cost of a lameduck government? Most importantly, is the present standoff a pause to find a solution or a pause to kill the deal?

Our cover story looks at all these questions and the prospect of a snap poll. Just how prepared are the major parties to face the electorate? What will be their electoral strategy and the political realignments that could emerge. Also, we look at the key question of the nuclear deal and the costs of either diluting or scrapping it. We compare our deal with the nuclear deal between China and the US.

It is not just the unnecessary expense, time and energy involved in unscheduled polls but the larger consequences: the serious setback to the economy at a time when India is poised to make giant strides, the loss of credibility in the global arena, the instability that such a step will bring and the opportunistic political realignments that will inevitably take place in the struggle to form the next government.

They say that a week is a long time in politics. For the country, the next few days will seem like a lifetime and could well decide its future, as a confident, stable, emerging power or a ramshackle, unstable, undependable third world country controlled by outdated ideologies perpetually missing the bus.

Aroon Purie

(Aroon Purie)

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